



From Poverty to Gang Involvement:

Understanding Systemic and Intergenerational Trauma in LA County

Why Poverty Matters More Than We Think

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Problem Statement



Los Angeles County youth from impoverished families experience systemic and intergenerational trauma as a result of historic factors, which leads to institutional distrust and increases vulnerability to gang affiliation.



Context

The United States was constructed on a narrative of democracy and societal progress. The reality of this construction is that institutions in this country make it fundamentally difficult for some to contribute to this narrative. Los Angeles County is a microcosm of the United States, and should be treated as such in assessing and reducing the effects of systemic and intergenerational traumas in conjunction with poverty.



Causal Chain

Historic Structural Inequalities →

Intergenerational Trauma →

Institutional Distrust →

Gang Vulnerability

So, the question remains, “how do we develop our research methods and practices to assist with intervention?”



History: Research, Practice, Policy



History: Research

I. California Poverty Measure (CPM) 2023

- Los Angeles County faces a child poverty rate as high as 68% in some cities, East LA, and East Vernon, whereas 4% in cities like Manhattan Beach.
- The youth in these disadvantaged neighborhoods likely come from
 1. Families with unemployed parents (29.8%)
 2. Single-parent families (25.6%)
 3. Families where the oldest adult is not a U.S. citizen (24.1%)

II. Historic Redlining

- a. Redlining (1930s-1960s) confined Latino and Black families to high-poverty neighborhoods
- b. These areas continue to experience racialized disinvestment, showing that systemic poverty, racism, and discrimination make it harder for minorities to be seen and represented in a society that wants them gone.

History: Research



III. Intergenerational Trauma – National Council on Family Relations (2018)

- “about 5 million children have experienced the incarceration of a residential parent at some point during their childhood” – increases the risk of child homelessness
- Children of incarcerated parents are at least twice as likely to suffer from anxiety, learning disabilities, or ADHD
- This intergenerational policing cycle continues as approximately 32% of incarcerated parents themselves had an incarcerated parent/guardian before they turned 18.

IV. Made in America: Bloods & Crips

- Interviewee: “She was too busy making a living then to love me, my whole life I tried figuring out why my mother didn’t love me. She didn’t once give me a hug or a kiss”.
 - a. Most of the gang members shown in the film lacked a present father figure and were raised by a single mother who also showed limited-to-no love = intersection between family systems and their relation to gang affiliation

History: Research continued



Trauma Exposure in Urban Poverty:

70-100% of children
in poor inner city
neighborhoods
experience trauma

(Dempsey, Overstreet, &
Moely, 2000; Fitzpatrick &
Boldizar, 1993; Macy, Barry, &
Noam, 2003)

83% of inner-city
youth report ≥ 1
traumatic event

(NCCP, 2007; 2008)

24-34% develop
PTSD from urban
community
violence

(Wethington et al.,
2008)

1 in 10
children
under age 6
witness
shooting/sta
bbing

(Groves, 2002)

History: Research continued



Neuroscience Findings:

- Poverty impacts brain development from infancy
- Reduced gray matter in hippocampus, frontal lobe, temporal lobe
- Chronic stress and daily violence exposure keeps brain in constant high-alert state impairing planning, goal-setting, & emotional regulation
- Effects visible in children as young as 5 months old

History: Practices/Programs in LA County



I.



- a. Provides case management, family services, and community intervention
- b. Uses risk assessments to connect high-risk youth to mentorship, therapy, and restorative activities

Strengths: evidence-informed model focusing on intervention, not suppression

Weaknesses:

- Caseloads are often high, which means inconsistent implementation across “gryd zones.”
- Only applies to select zones based on past gang data + gang database

II. Trauma-Focused Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (TF-CBT)

- 12-week individual/group treatment for ages 3-17
- Most empirically supported intervention for childhood trauma
- **Parent-Child Relationship Interventions**
 - Parent-Child Interaction Therapy (PCIT)** - 80+ studies
 - Child-Parent Psychotherapy (CPP) - for ages 0-6 with DV exposure

History: Current Policies



1. LA County's "Care First, Jails Last" Plan

Goal: Reduce incarceration by providing treatment and services as alternatives to arrest and incarceration.

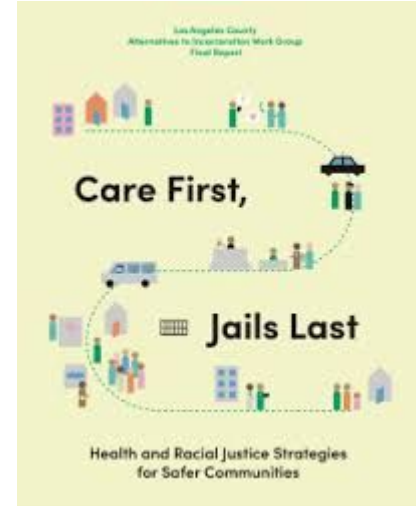
- a. E.g., scaling back cash bail, expanding community-based initiatives, funding youth programs, providing interim housing for those exiting jail, etc.

Strengths:

- a. Recognizes that trauma and poverty are core components of crime/gang affiliation

Weaknesses:

- a. Funding setbacks
- b. Political resistance



History: Current Policies

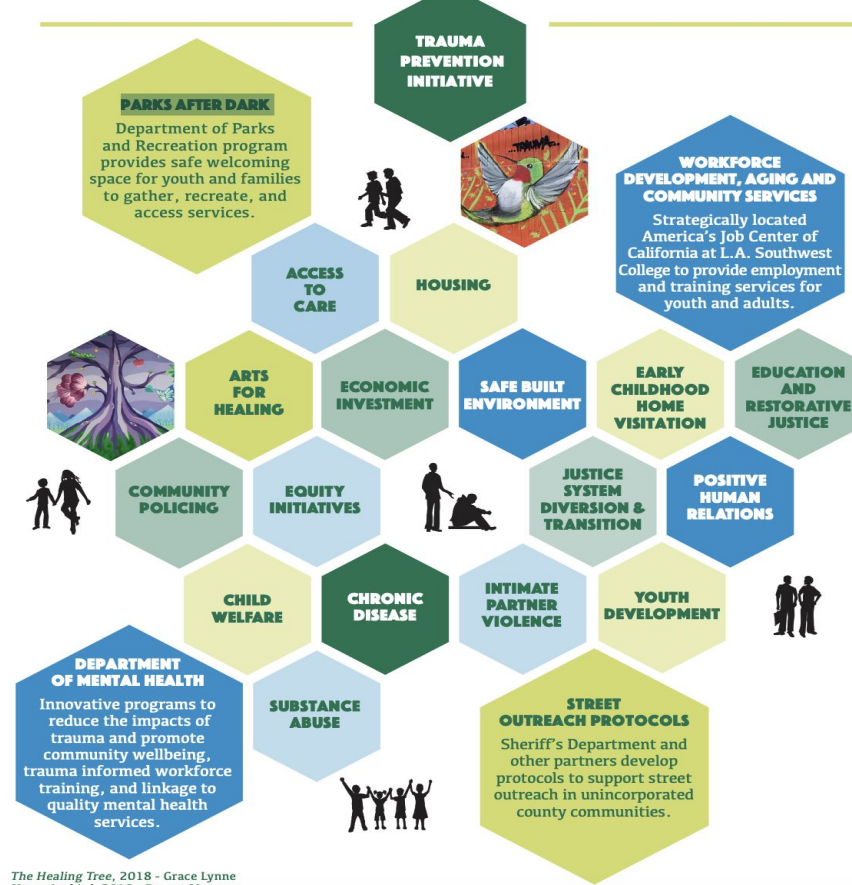


1. LA County Trauma Prevention Initiative (TPI, 2015)

Model: Public health approach to violence prevention

Three-Pronged Strategy:

1. **Intervention** - Hospital-Based Violence Intervention (HBVI), street outreach, conflict mediation
2. **Capacity Building** - Training for grassroots orgs, Peer-to-Peer Learning Academy, trauma-informed workforce
3. **Prevention** - Community empowerment, Parks After Dark, arts for healing, early childhood visitation



*The Healing Tree, 2018 - Grace Lynne
Hummingbird 2018 - Brvant Manoum*



Recommendations & Cost Benefit Analysis



Recommendations & Cost-Benefit Analysis

1. Micro Level recommendation

Trauma-Informed Family Therapy in Family Shelters

- Expand DMH + LAHSA partnership so ALL family shelters offer trauma-informed, family-centered counseling.
- Provide trauma screening for youth & caregivers (stress, safety, communication).
- Offer short-term family therapy (6–12 weeks): conflict de-escalation, emotional regulation, trauma psychoeducation.
- Warm handoffs to GRYD workers, YDD case managers, and school counselors for continuity of care.

2. Mezzo Level Recommendation

Family Resilience Hubs in GRYD Zones

- Create trauma-informed community hubs that co-locate youth programs, mental-health services, credible messengers, and benefits navigation.
- Build on existing GRYD centers, CFCI hubs, DMH community clinics, and resilience hubs already in place.
- Provide tutoring, mentoring, arts/sports, counseling, crisis support, and parent groups, all in one coordinated space.
- Strengthens family stability, belonging, routine, and prosocial identity to prevent gang involvement.



Recommendations & Cost-Benefit Analysis

3. Macro Level Recommendation

Countywide Policy Changes supporting Prevention

- Redirect funding toward trauma-informed programs (CFCI).
- Require cross-system coordination (schools, shelters, GRYD, YDD, DMH).
- Corporate accountability: internships & youth employment pipelines.
- Multi-year funding contracts to stabilize services

4. Cost-Benefit Analysis (CBA)

Fiscal Impact of trauma-Informed Services & Family Resilience Hubs

- Diversion reduces costly youth incarceration (~\$300k per youth per year).
- RAND: 61% of incarcerated individuals w/ mental-health needs qualify for diversion.
- Trauma-informed care reduces hospitalization & ER use by 30–50% in community models.
- Higher school completion → lifetime earnings increase \$630k–\$900k (SSA).
- BA completion reduces poverty from 13% → 4% and SNAP use from 14% → 3%.
- Education reduces welfare recidivism by 20–40% (London; Coelli et al.).



Budget: Potential Costs

Total Cost (1 Hub) = ~\$800,000



Personnel: ~\$665,000

Hub Coordinator	1 full time	\$75,000/yr
Licensed Mental Health Clinician	3 full time	\$75,000/yr (per clinician) x 3 = \$225,000
Family Case Manager	3 full time	\$65,000/yr (per case manager) x 3 = \$195,000
Mentors/Tutors (SOWK Undergrad & Grad Workers)	5 part time	\$18,000/yr (per mentor/tutor) x 5 = \$90,000/yr
Program Assistant/Admin Support	2 part time	\$25,000/yr (per program assistant/admin support) x 2 = \$50,000/yr
Arts & Receptions Coordinator	1 full time	\$30,000/yr

Other: ~\$135,000

Facilities (Rent/Utilities)	\$40,000
Programs/Services (Tutoring, Mentoring, Arts, Recreations, Counseling)	\$40,000
Materials/Supplies (Educational, Recreational, Equipment, Technology)	\$25,000
Partnerships (GRYD, DMH, LAHSA, YDD)	\$20,000
Miscellaneous (Events, Transportation)	\$10,000



Evaluation: Positive Impacts & Potential Downsides

Positive Impacts

Micro Level: Strengthens family structures by lowering familial stress which leads to the reduction of youth looking for outside support from gangs

Mezzo Level: Promotes community belonging, consistent routines, and positive social engagement, helping youth avoid the need to feel the sense of belonging from a gang.

Macro Level: Redirects county funds to trauma-informed programs that support prevention and intervention measures that can benefit communities as a whole.



Challenges



- Cost & Funding
- Shelter Capacity
- Family Engagement
- Cross Agency Coordination/Data Sharing

- Safety
- Respecting Diverse Cultural Backgrounds
- Community Trust Barriers

- Budget Reallocation
- Corporate Accountability
- Measuring Impact



Thank You! Q&A